

Strategy Knotworking

Liberating Structures Slowdown Series | April, May & June 2026

Session II

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Marchian Playfulness

"Gardeners accept [this] powerlessness in the face of the overwhelming forces of nature, but believe that they can nevertheless plant seeds at the appropriate time, pull up weeds regularly, and adapt their watering to the sunshine. These are the small, mundane actions that, performed with constancy, will ultimately yield more opportunities to foster the emergence of a world that is increasingly true, beautiful, and just."

From On Leadership by James March (pp. 112)

Impromptu Networking

*What does that passage make you think about?
How does it relate to your understanding of
strategy?*

A true Strategy Knotworking **Slow**down might look like several days, several months, or even several years...

Agenda Sequence

Session 1

Arriving & Settling

Knot By-the-Book (Rapid Writing)

Strategy Knotworking Background

Purpose

Baseline

Context

Conclusion

Session 2

Arriving & Settling

Recap Session 1

Context

Challenge

Ambitions

Conclusion

Session 3

Arriving & Settling

Recap Sessions 1 & 2

Action & Evaluation

Stories and Examples from Strategy Knotworking

Conclusion

Finding a Focus

Option 1: A current or upcoming project that you want to generate a strategy for

Option 2: A change or transition you are anticipating

Option 3: If you have a business, practice, organization, or community you are part of and want to elaborate on the strategy for it, you can pick that, too

Narrow in on something tangible.

Strategy Knotworking

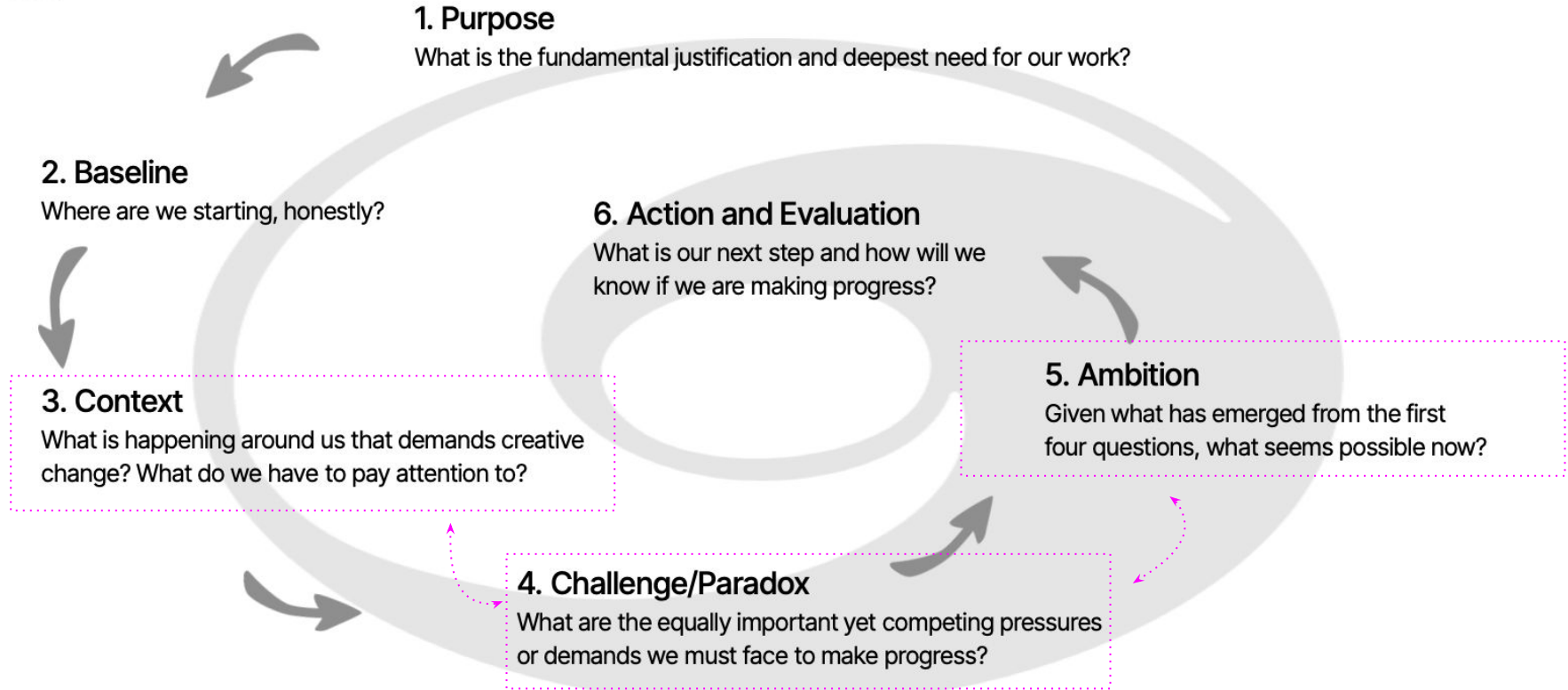
Purpose: Answer Six Questions Together to Develop
Strategy Everyone Owns

Purposes

In Strategy Knotworking (SKW), participants answer six questions to develop a strategic initiative in a complex context. It is designed to engage everyone who will execute the strategy in its development, building shared ownership of higher-order goals and capacity to respond to uncertainty. SKW reinforces the LS principle *Amplify Freedom and Responsibility*.



Strategy Knotworking (SKW) Template



Strategy Knotworking as...

- Umbrella, with LS Nested within
- Ecosystem, Garden, Forest
- Approach for Ongoing Attunement
- Scaffolding for Individual Transitions
- Kaleidoscope

Contexts

What is happening around us that demands creative adaptation & change?

What is critical and uncertain about the future of our work?

What are people seeing, hearing, feeling, sensing, noticing, and observing about the internal & external environment we're operating within/across?

What are the weak & strong signals we need to tune into?

Contexts: **things we consider**

Tuning to context must be ongoing; it's central to adaptation and adaptive strategy.

Context often is the element that thrusts current work into Rigidity Traps or Creative Destruction.

Context is everything! It drives how implementation is planned.

Context is people, sensemaking around purpose, shapes ambitions, and shapes how we think about Action and Evaluation.

Context: Method Choices

- Learning Histories ([DC User Group Session Slides](#))
- What, So What, Now What
- Simple Ethnography
- 1-2-4-All
- **Conversation Cafe**
- **Spiral Journal**
- **Variables for Critical Uncertainties**

Challenges

What are the paradoxical realities we must work with in order to make progress?

What polarities make our work complex?

What is the nature of the challenges we face and **how might we respond?**

Challenge: Method Choices

- **Critical Uncertainties**
- Polarities Mapping
- **Wicked Questions**
- Agreement~Certainty Matrix
- Social Network Mapping/Webbing
- TRIZ/ Creative Destruction

Ambitions

What seems possible now?

What strategies/ activities will move us forward?

What needs are we prepared to meet?

What can we meaningfully include?

What needs to be excluded?

What principles will help us **prioritize**?

What choices are consistent with our purpose, principles, and capacities?

What is our theory of change & logic model?

Ambitions: Method Choices

- **Critical Uncertainties**
- 25/10 Crowdsourcing
- Future~Present
- Min Specs
- Wicked Questions & Integrated Autonomy
- Panarchy
- 1-2-4-All
- **What, So What, Now What to Harvest & Synthesize**

Complexity Theory and Strategy

- Less Visioning, More Identifying Immediate Next Steps
 - With Future~Present
 - The output is more to identify steps going forward more than try to envision an ideal future state perfectly
- Adjacent Possible (Stuart Kauffman)
 - What is needed to create the conditions for the adjacent possible to emerge/ be pursued?
- Mapping Strategies to Nature of the Work (e.g. Cynefin & Dave Snowden)

Context: Spiral Journal

Divide a piece of paper into four parts
(fold it, draw a big plus sign)



Prompts

When it comes to this (project, change, upcoming period of time) what are you...

- Aware of in its context? What is happening in the environment as it relates to this work?
- Preparing for, expecting, and imagining?
- Trying to balance or keep in tension?
- Tuning into as an opportunity?

Challenge & Context: Conversation Cafe

What is happening in your context that invites you to adapt, evolve, or radically change? What are the opportunities and/or uncertainties you are attuning to?

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Round 1: Each participant is invited to briefly sharing what they are thinking, feeling, or doing about the theme or topic (5 mins), one by one.

When you are done speaking, pass the “turn” to someone else by name.

Round 2: Everyone is invited to contribute again after hearing initial responses (5 mins).

Round 3: Everyone is invited to contribute via open discussion (7 minutes).

Round 4: Each participant is invited to share their takeaways, using the person-by-person approach of the first and second rounds (5 mins).

Challenges & Ambitions: Critical Uncertainties

Sequence of Steps

1. Write down a list of uncertainties related to the future of (X). Then create 4 scenarios to work with. You should have a starting list of these from your Context YxN Writing.
2. Begin elaborating on each scenario, starting with a name, then a brief narrative description, before generating ideas for successfully operating within that scenario.
3. Analyze outputs from across groups looking for robust and hedging bets.

A good uncertainty is something that you have very little control or influence over AND is difficult to predict in detail. You may have a sense of which way it will go, but you can't really know beforehand.

Review your list from YxN Writing under Context. See if you can refine those as uncertainties.

When coming up with your list try to avoid putting value on the items.

For example: Try to avoid statements like “Not having enough money” and instead phrase the uncertainty around your financial situation or sense of security. We will add the value dimensions in the next step.

Example Uncertainties - Personal

- Physical health and wellbeing as I age
- Financial security in 25 years
- Satisfaction with the work I am doing
- Relational durability and longevity
- Family and partner needs
- Sense of ambition and future professional desires

Example Uncertainties - Organizational

- Product pipeline and development of new services, programs, or projects
- Funding levels
- Community interest in our work
- Political, regulatory, & policy environment we are operating in
- People's interest in working for or with us
- Competitive landscape and future innovations in our space
- Technology evolution and its impact on our core business operations
- The social interests and values of our customers/clients/users

Once you have a list of uncertainties, pick 2 that feel like they would have the biggest impact on your focus area.

Then for each uncertainty, try to name the extreme states for it. Usually, these are very negative or very positive extremes, but not always depending on the uncertainties you selected.

Example Uncertainties - Personal

- Physical health and wellbeing as I age:
 - My health is robust enough to maintain independence ~ My health is fragile and it's difficult to maintain ADLs on my own
- Financial security in 2-5 years
 - I have enough money to feel stable and maintain my quality of life ~ My finances are precarious and insecure
- Satisfaction with the work I am doing
 - I am finding and doing meaningful work ~ The work I do is unsatisfying and meaningless
- Relational durability and longevity
- Family and partner needs
- Sense of ambition and future professional desires
 - My ambitions/desires remain the same ~ They change dramatically

Example Uncertainties - Organizational

- Product pipeline and development of new services, programs, or projects
 - Gushing pipeline of innovative new products/services ~ Trickleing pipeline of new products and services
- Funding levels
 - Rush to fund our kind of work ~ Funding remains fragmented and minimal
- Community interest in our work
 - People are enthusiastic, interested, and excited about our work ~ People are disinterested, uninspired, and bored of our work
- Political, regulatory, & policy environment we are operating in
 - Stable and robust ~ Loosey goosey
- People's interest in working for or with us
- Competitive landscape and future innovations in our space
 - Few competitors ~ Many upstarts
- Technology evolution and its impact on our core business operations
- The social interests and values of our customers/clients/users

Scenario A

Scenario B

Secure



Finances

Health

Robust

Fragile

Scenario D

Scenario C

Precarious

Then begin identifying strategies, investments, and activities for thriving/surviving/adapting IN THAT SCENARIO. If you really have named true uncertainties it is very very difficult to change those circumstances. So, try to avoid naming things that get you OUT of the scenario and instead try to identify things that let you work successfully WITHIN it.

Scenario A

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Scenario D

TBD

Strategy
Idea

Scenario B

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

TBD

Strategy
Idea

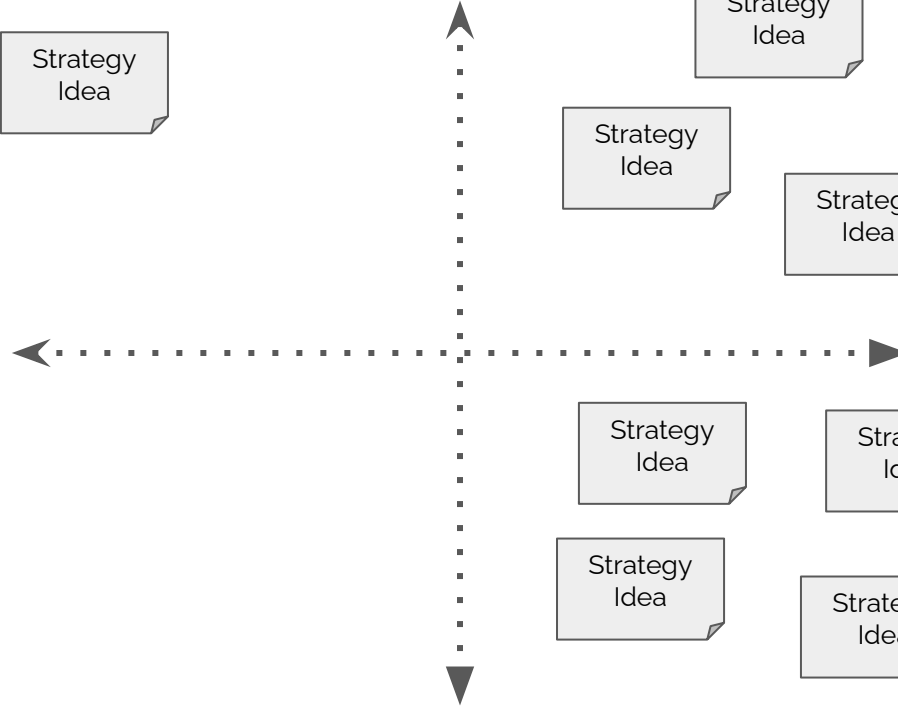
Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Strategy
Idea

Scenario C

TBD



Scenario A

TBD

Scenario B

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

TBD

Strategy Idea

Scenario D

TBD

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

TBD

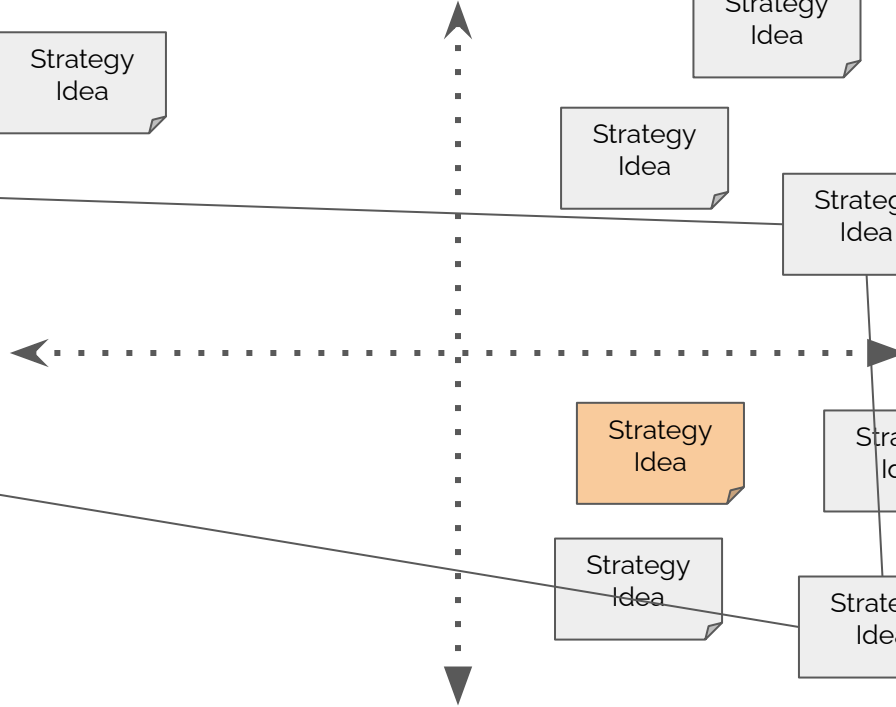
Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Strategy Idea

Scenario C



In the final step, look across all the strategies you identified and see if there are any that are similar to each other or ones that particularly stand out.

We are trying to find:

Robust strategies - Options and solutions that work in multiple scenarios

Hedging bets - Good ideas that are worth investing in now so that if a particular future plays out we are prepared for it

Closing and What's Next

- June 9 Speculations on... something: <https://lsspeculations.eventbrite.com>
- June 16 session on Knotworking: <https://ls-slowdown.eventbrite.com>
 - Action & Evaluation
 - Story gathering - so if you have an experience with Knotworking that you want to share it'll be a good chance to do that or hear how other people are localizing it